

An example, not a tested adventure. This one-shot shows what the gurps -press package can do: stat blocks, dice, book references and the Steve Jackson Games notices. Nobody has playtested it. Check the numbers before you use it at your table.

The Tortoise and the Hare

A one-shot adventure for **GURPS** Fourth Edition

One player and a GM · About 45 minutes · A 50-point hero

Introduction

Everybody knows how this race ends. Or do they? In this one-shot, the oldest race in the world is run again, and this time the dice decide. One player is the Tortoise: slow, stubborn and very hard to stop. The GM plays the Hare: the fastest animal in the meadow, and the first to say so.

The adventure is short. It fits in a lunch break. It needs one player, one GM, three six-sided dice and the **GURPS Basic Set**. New players learn Quick Contests and self-control rolls.

A Hare one day ridiculed the short feet and slow pace of the Tortoise, who replied, laughing: "Though you be swift as the wind, I will beat you in a race."

— Aesop, "The Hare and the Tortoise", translated by George Fyler Townsend (1867). Each quotation in this style is from this fable.

How to Use This Adventure

Read it once before you play. Give the player the Tortoise's stat block, or let the player build a Tortoise on 50 points. Then read "The Challenge" aloud, and play the race.

The Meadow

The meadow lies between the old oak and the mill pond. Rabbits, mice and a very old Fox live there. Nothing much happens in the meadow, and the animals like it that way. Then the Hare starts to boast.

The Challenge

Read aloud: "Under the old oak, the Hare stretches its long legs. 'Not one of you,' it says, 'could beat me from here to the mill pond.' The mice look away. The rabbits look at their feet. Then a slow voice comes from the grass: 'I could.'"

The Hare laughs so hard that it falls over. Then it accepts.

The Hare, believing her assertion to be simply impossible, assented to the proposal; and they agreed that the Fox should choose the course and fix the goal.

— Aesop

The Racers

The Tortoise

The Tortoise has a shell like a cobblestone and a will like a mule. It cannot run at all. It walks, it does not stop and it does not tire: that is its Hiking skill.

The Tortoise (50 points)

ST 7 [-30]; DX 10 [0]; IQ 11 [20]; HT 13 [30].

HP 10 [6]; Will 13 [10]; Per 11 [0]; FP 13 [0].

Basic Speed 5.75 [0]; Basic Move 1 [-20]; Dodge 8.

SM -3; DR 3 (shell); thr 1d-3; sw 1d-2.

Advantages: Damage Resistance (Tough Shell) 3 [15]; Very Fit [15].

Disadvantages: Stubbornness [-5].

Quirks: Never hurries [-1].

Skills: Fast-Talk-12 [4]; Hiking-14 [4]; Survival (Woodlands)-11 [2].

The Hare

The Hare is the fastest animal in the meadow. It also has Overconfidence (p. B148): it cannot believe that it could lose.

The Hare (59 points)

ST 6 [-40]; DX 13 [60]; IQ 10 [0]; HT 11 [10].

HP 6 [0]; Will 10 [0]; Per 10 [0]; FP 11 [0].

Basic Speed 6.00 [0]; Basic Move 9 [15]; Dodge 9.

SM -2; DR 0; thr 1d-4; sw 1d-3.

Disadvantages: Overconfidence (12) [-5].

Quirks: Naps after lunch [-1].

Skills: Running-16 [20].

Attacks:

Kick (13): 1d-4 cr. Reach C.

The Course

The Fox walks the course and plants a feather at the goal. It is one mile long and has three landmarks.

- **The clover patch.** Halfway. The clover is sweet and the sun is warm. It is a very good place for a nap.
- **The hedge.** A thick hawthorn hedge with one small gap at the bottom. At SM -3, the Tortoise fits through the gap. At SM -2, the Hare does not, and must run around.
- **The mill pond.** The goal. The Fox waits there to judge the finish.

The Race

The Tortoise never for a moment stopped, but went on with a slow but steady pace straight to the end of the course.

— Aesop

Play the race in three steps.

1. **Taunt (optional).** At the start, the Tortoise can mock the Hare. Roll a Quick Contest (p. B348) of the Tortoise's Fast-Talk-12 against the Hare's Will of 10. If the Tortoise wins, the Hare takes -4 on its roll in step 2.
2. **The nap.** At the clover patch, the Hare is far ahead. The GM rolls 3d against the Hare's self-control number of 12 (p. B120). On a failure, the Hare lies down for a nap.
3. **The finish.** Roll a Quick Contest: the Tortoise's Hiking-14 (p. B200) against the Hare's Running-16 (p. B218). The Hare gets +4 for its speed. If it took a nap, it gets -4 instead. If the player says that the Tortoise uses the gap in the hedge, the Tortoise gets +2. The winner reaches the pond first. On a tie, the Tortoise wins by the length of its nose.

Designer's note. These odds are calculated, not playtested. If the player only walks, the Tortoise wins 26% of races. With the hedge, it wins 37%. With the taunt, 45%. With the taunt and the hedge, 57%. Even against the hedge, an awake Hare wins 79% of races, and a sleeping Hare loses 86%. Clever play pays, as it should.

The Hare, lying down by the wayside, fell fast asleep.

— Aesop

After the Race

If the Tortoise wins, the meadow cheers, and the Hare is quiet for a whole week. If the Hare wins, it boasts until the leaves fall. Either way, the story is over: this one-shot does not lead to a campaign.

Slow but steady wins the race.

— Aesop

Variations

- **More players.** Each extra player is another slow animal: a snail, a hedgehog or a mole. Each one rolls its own Quick Contest against the Hare.
- **A rematch.** The Hare has learned its lesson. It has no Overconfidence, so skip step 2. Can the Tortoise still win?

About This Adventure

Author. Nathanael Farley, October 2026.

Use of AI. Claude Opus 5.5, an AI model by Anthropic, was used to draft the text, the characters and the race rules, to calculate the odds, and to typeset the adventure. Nathanael Farley gave the directions and reviewed the result.

Tools. Typeset with `Typst` and `gurps-press` 0.1.0. The source of this adventure is `docs/example/tortoise-and-hare.typ` in the `gurps-press` repository. The odds in the designer's note were calculated exactly from the rules; `docs/example/odds.typ` shows how.

References.

- Aesop, “The Hare and the Tortoise”, in *Aesop's Fables*, translated by George Fyler Townsend (1867). Public domain. The italic quotations come from this translation.
- **GURPS Basic Set**, Fourth Edition, Steve Jackson Games. Rules cited: self-control rolls (p. B120), Overconfidence (p. B148), Hiking (p. B200), Running (p. B218), Quick Contests (p. B348).
- Steve Jackson Games, Online Policy: the disclaimer and the notice below.
- Steve Jackson Games, Authors' Guidelines: Editorial Style: dice, book titles and page references.

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Appendix: The Odds

The designer's note gives exact odds, not playtest results. This appendix shows how to calculate them from the rules of the *GURPS Basic Set*. Typst calculates the numbers on this page when it typesets the adventure.

One Roll

Three dice can show k in $N(k)$ ways, out of $6^3 = 216$. For example, $N(10) = 27$. So

$$P(3d = k) = \frac{N(k)}{216}.$$

A success roll against skill s succeeds on $k \leq s$, with two exceptions (p. B348): $k \leq 4$ always succeeds, and $k = 18$ (or $k = 17$ when $s \leq 15$) always fails. Write $S(s)$ for the chance of success:

$$S(s) = \sum_{k=3}^{18} P(3d = k) \cdot \mathbb{1}[k \text{ succeeds against } s]$$

For the Hare's self-control number, $S(12) = \frac{160}{216} \approx 74\%$. After a taunt, it is $S(8) = \frac{56}{216} \approx 26\%$.

Quick Contests

The margin of a roll is $m = s - k$. In a Quick Contest of skill a against skill b , a wins if only a succeeds, or if both succeed or both fail and a has the larger margin. Write $W(a, b)$ for the chance that a wins or ties:

$$W(a, b) = \sum_{k=3}^{18} \sum_{l=3}^{18} P(3d = k) P(3d = l) \cdot \mathbb{1}[a \text{ wins or ties } b]$$

The Race

Let $t = 1$ if the taunt works, $n = 1$ if the Hare naps, and $g = 1$ if the Tortoise uses the gap in the hedge. The taunt works with chance $T = 64\%$, a Quick Contest of Fast-Talk-12 against Will 10. Then

$$P(n = 1 \mid t) = 1 - S(12 - 4t)$$

and the Tortoise wins the race with chance

$$P_{\text{win}} = \sum_{t \in \{0,1\}} \sum_{n \in \{0,1\}} P(t) \cdot P(n \mid t) \cdot W(14 + 2g, 20 - 8n).$$

The player	The Tortoise wins
Only walks	26%
Uses the gap in the hedge	37%
Taunts the Hare	45%
Taunts the Hare and uses the gap	57%

The Same Calculation in Python

This program gives the same numbers. Change the numbers at the top to test your own version of the race.

```
"""Exact odds for the race in The Tortoise and the Hare.
```

```
Rules (GURPS Basic Set): a success roll is 3d against the effective
skill; 3 and 4 always succeed, 17 fails at skill 15 or less, 18 always
fails (p. B348). In a Quick Contest both sides roll; the one who succeeds
by more, or fails by less, wins (p. B348). A tie in the taunt has no
effect; a tie at the finish goes to the Tortoise.
"""
```

```
from itertools import product
```

```
# The numbers in the adventure.
```

```
FAST_TALK, HARE_WILL = 12, 10 # step 1: the taunt
TAUNT_PENALTY = 4 # to the Hare's self-control roll
SELF_CONTROL = 12 # step 2: Overconfidence (12)
HIKING, RUNNING = 14, 16 # step 3: the finish
AWAKE_BONUS, NAP_PENALTY = 4, 4 # the Hare's speed, or its nap
HEDGE_BONUS = 2 # the Tortoise uses the gap in the hedge
```

```
P3D = {}
```

```
for dice in product(range(1, 7), repeat=3):
    P3D[sum(dice)] = P3D.get(sum(dice), 0) + 1 / 216
```

```
def roll(skill, total):
```

```
    """(success, margin) of one success roll."""
```

```
    if total <= 4:
```

```
        success = True
```

```
    elif total == 18 or (total == 17 and skill <= 15):
```

```
        success = False
```

```
    else:
```

```
        success = total <= skill
```

```
    return success, skill - total
```

```
def p_success(skill):
```

```
    return sum(p for total, p in P3D.items() if roll(skill, total)[0])
```

```
def p_first_wins_or_ties(a, b):
```

```
    """Return (P(a wins), P(tie)) in a Quick Contest of a against b."""
```

```
    win = tie = 0.0
```

```
    for ta, pa in P3D.items():
```

```
        sa, ma = roll(a, ta)
```

```
        for tb, pb in P3D.items():
```

```
            sb, mb = roll(b, tb)
```

```
            if (sa and not sb) or (sa == sb and ma > mb):
```

```
                win += pa * pb
```

```
            elif sa == sb and ma == mb:
```

```
                tie += pa * pb
```

```
    return win, tie
```

```
def p_tortoise_wins(taunt, hedge):
```

```
    p_taunt = p_first_wins_or_ties(FAST_TALK, HARE_WILL)[0] if taunt else 0
```

```
    tortoise = HIKING + (HEDGE_BONUS if hedge else 0)
```

```
    total = 0.0
```

```
    for taunted, p1 in ((True, p_taunt), (False, 1 - p_taunt)):
```

```
        p_nap = 1 - p_success(SELF_CONTROL - (TAUNT_PENALTY if taunted else 0))
```

```

        for napped, p2 in ((True, p_nap), (False, 1 - p_nap)):
            hare = RUNNING + (-NAP_PENALTY if napped else AWAKE_BONUS)
            total += p1 * p2 * sum(p_first_wins_or_ties(tortoise, hare))
    return total

if __name__ == "__main__":
    for taunt, hedge, label in (
        (False, False, "only walks"),
        (False, True, "uses the hedge"),
        (True, False, "taunts"),
        (True, True, "taunts and uses the hedge"),
    ):
        print(f"Tortoise {label}: wins {p_tortoise_wins(taunt, hedge):.0%}")
    tortoise = HIKING + HEDGE_BONUS
    awake = 1 - sum(p_first_wins_or_ties(tortoise, RUNNING + AWAKE_BONUS))
    asleep = sum(p_first_wins_or_ties(tortoise, RUNNING - NAP_PENALTY))
    print(f"Against the hedge, an awake Hare wins {awake:.0%}")
    print(f"Against the hedge, a sleeping Hare loses {asleep:.0%}")

```